



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Yellowstone Schools

School Website: <https://www.yellowstoneschools.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Yellowstone Schools TX 77004 presents as a hybrid private-Christian and public-charter model operating on a single campus in Houston's Third Ward. Public materials emphasize a faith-informed, formation-oriented approach with a strong emphasis on moral development, character formation, and college-preparatory opportunities (e.g., dual enrollment and early college credits). The website highlights small class sizes, family partnerships, and a mission to prepare students for life beyond high school, including college and career pathways. While the school foregrounds formation, virtue, and faith, explicit Great Books, classical grammar-logic-rhetoric curriculum, and SrOSc-based Socratic pedagogy are not clearly documented on the site. Taken together, Yellowstone demonstrates meaningful classical-adjacent signals (formation, virtue, theology, community partnership) but lacks consistent, explicit articulation of core classical curriculum and pedagogy beyond formation and college-prep framing.

Overall classification (aggregate): SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Core strengths (signals of classical orientation): explicit theology and moral formation; formation-focused mission; partnership with families; emphasis on small class sizes and teacher dedication; aspiration to prepare students for college and life beyond high school.
- Gaps relative to a fully classical model: absence of clearly stated Great Books/Great Conversation reading programs, explicit Trivium-based curriculum (grammar-logic-rhetoric), and explicit Socratic pedagogy in upper grades within public-facing materials; limited public mentions of liturgical practices or formal catechesis in the classroom context.

What would move the needle: to shift toward CLASSICAL, Yellowstone could articulate and expand explicit classical elements such as a described Great Books program and a Trivium-based curriculum, embed Socratic seminars in upper grades, highlight a more explicit "living curriculum" approach by faculty, and more clearly connect liturgical or sacred-text-based inquiry across disciplines. Strengthening parent education and public-facing documentation of these elements would also advance perceived classical alignment.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials consistently describe Yellowstone as "rooted in the Christian faith" and "private Christian" in its founding and operations. This framing appears across core pages introducing the school and its mission. - The mission/vision language emphasizes faith, moral foundations, and forming students for life beyond school, consistent with a theologically-grounded educational ethos. - Public materials note God-given potential and faith-based aims (e.g., "God-given potential" language in materials describing graduates' postsecondary pathways).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present in public materials include: faith-based grounding, moral foundation, virtue/character formation, and God-centered purpose (aligned with terms such as virtue, character, moral formation, and theology in the classical lexicon). See the Six Essential Elements positive indicators (e.g., virtue, character, moral formation; sacred tradition; theology). - Negative indicators: not evident in public materials; liturgical practices are not described in the classroom context, and explicit liturgical/catechetical programming is not documented on public pages. Negative signals from the classical lexicon emphasize absence of liturgical practices, overt secularization, or relativism, none of which are clearly evidenced here.

Why this rating - Yellowstone demonstrates a clear religious foundation and moral formation emphasis (signals of the religious/metaphysical dimension) but lacks explicit, detailed reporting of liturgical practices or theology integration across all subjects in a documented way. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating, reflecting strong religious framing but incomplete explicit classical-education scaffolding in pedagogy/curriculum documentation. The Positive keyword indicators from the classical Elements lexicon (virtue, character, moral formation, theology) align with this assessment, while the absence of clearly documented liturgical integration lowers it from CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school's mission emphasizes faith, character formation, and life-change, suggesting formation-oriented aims over mere information transfer. - Public materials emphasize preparing students for life after high school, including college-readiness and dual-enrollment pathways; the school aligns with a college- and career-prep trajectory, though framed within a faith-formation context. - Five-year strategic vision and mission statements emphasize growth, potential realization, and life outcomes beyond schooling.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators (formation, virtue, telos, wisdom, human flourishing, ultimate ends) appear in statements about faith-led formation, character development, and life-purpose goals; these map to positive elements such as formation, virtue, human flourishing, and moral imagination in the classical lexicon. - Negative indicators: explicit emphasis on college readiness and dual enrollment signals some alignment with workforce/academic pathways that can drift toward utilitarian aims when presented without strong formation context; however, the public emphasis remains on formation and faith-led purpose rather than mere job-prep. The presence of “career” language alongside “college” in the Yellowstone materials contributes to a nuanced reading. Negative signals in the classical lexicon include overemphasis on workforce/career readiness at the expense of formation; this is only partially evidenced here.

Why this rating - The public materials emphasize formation, virtue, and life-long human flourishing, not only information or job-readiness. Yet the presence of explicit college/career pathways and dual-enrollment language somewhat tempers the pure formation aim. Taken together, this yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating, given a strong formation orientation but with ongoing alignment toward college/career pathways rather than a strictly classical telos. The classical-keyword framework supports this reading, as there is substantial alignment with formation and truth/goodness/beauty concepts, but less explicit “telos” articulation beyond college readiness.

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public site materials emphasize a private-Christian and charter blend with a focus on college-prep and a campus/community orientation rather than a described liberal arts curriculum built on grammar, logic, and rhetoric. - There is explicit mention of dual enrollment and early-college pathways, but no clear documentation of liberal arts core contents (grammar, logic, rhetoric), classical history as core across the curriculum, Great Books reading, or a Great Conversation framework. - The site highlights history and other content in a more contemporary, college-prep framing rather than standard classical “history-as-long-curriculum” framing.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive classical curriculum indicators (grammar/logic/rhetoric, Great Books, Great Conversation, history as a continuous through-line, wonder) are largely absent in public-facing

Yellowstone materials; relevant terms rarely appear. The absence of Great Books/Great Conversation references is a notable negative signal for a classical curriculum. Classical-lexicon positive terms such as grammar, logic, rhetoric, and Great Books do not appear in the public pages. - Negative keywords: the dominance of college-prep, dual enrollment, and vocational/college pathways in the public-facing materials aligns with non-classical or non-traditionally classical framing rather than a pure classical literature/history-centric approach. This aligns with the “no Great Books/history-focused through-line” signal in the lexicon.

Why this rating - The curriculum is not documented as classical in form (grammar-logic-rhetoric, Great Books, Great Conversation, history as the overarching through-line). The emphasis on private-Christian/charter combination and college preparation signals a move away from the core Classical liberal arts model. Therefore, Element 3 is rated NOT CLASSICAL.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials do not clearly describe Socratic seminars, dialectic pedagogy, or other explicit classical teaching methods. The website highlights small class sizes and teacher care, but does not document structured Socratic discussions or a sustained, high-level classical pedagogy in the public-facing materials. - There is no explicit mention of □□□ chanting, scholé days, or contemplative, restful learning in the classroom (lower school singing/chanting, etc.). The materials do not provide a clear, documented pathway to a classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators from the classical pedagogy lexicon (Socratic dialogue, scholé, memorization through chant, upper-level rhetoric/moots) are not evidenced in Yellowstone’s public content; thus, negative signals for classical pedagogy are minimal, but the absence of these elements counts as a major gap. - The presence of “small class sizes” and “highly engaged teachers” aligns with positive teaching culture but not the formal classical pedagogy markers. The lexicon indicates the presence of Socratic seminars, memorization, and chant as key pedagogy signals; these are not publicly documented here.

Why this rating - Without explicit documentation of Socratic inquiry, scholé, or classical memory routines in the public materials, Element 4 is NOT CLASSICAL. The school’s formation emphasis is strong, but the pedagogy is not publicly described in classical terms.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Yellowstone lists a leadership team (superintendent, chief of staff, principals) and a board of directors, indicating formal structure and governance. This supports an orderly, mentorship-oriented environment, a hallmark of “living curriculum” in classical thought, even though it is not described as such. - The site emphasizes teacher dedication, small class sizes, and supportive professional development in the “Yellowstone Differences” materials; it also references teacher care and a mission to “change lives,” which aligns with the human-formation role of faculty in classical education. - The presence of career postings and a robust faculty/administration structure demonstrates a committed professional staff, though not a direct claim that they embody the “living curriculum” or “portrait of teacher” archetypes found in classical material.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators from the classical lexicon include “portrait of a teacher,” “living curriculum,” “faculty as mentors,” and “collegial culture.” Yellowstone’s leadership and faculty emphasis (leadership team, board, teacher postings, small classes, professional development) loosely aligns with these themes, but direct language about the faculty as “living curriculum” or “portrait of a teacher” is not explicit in the public text. Therefore, a partial match occurs. - Negative signals: not strongly evidenced; there is no explicit negative indication. The absence of explicit statements like “faculty as living curriculum” lowers the score compared to a fully classical articulation.

Why this rating - Yellowstone demonstrates credible faculty structure, mentorship orientation, and a desire for teacher development, which aligns with some classical expectations of the “living curriculum.” However, due to the lack of explicit language about faculty as living curriculum or portrait-of-teacher concepts in public materials, Element 5 earns SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Yellowstone emphasizes partnerships with families and positions parents as co-teachers, a central classical principle. Materials explicitly discuss partnering with families “regardless of financial means,” and the campus/policy encourages active family involvement (volunteerism, attendance at family events). - The site mentions parental formation and education (e.g., promotion of family engagement, book studies, gatherings) and an open-campus ethos; parents are welcomed to visit, consistent with the classical emphasis on a close school-family community. - Communications emphasize community ties, donor/philanthropic activity, and ongoing parent engagement through events and volunteer opportunities.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators from the classical lexicon for this category include: partnership with families, parent formation, living tradition in the family, and parental engagement in classical education. Yellowstone’s materials strongly emphasize parent partnerships, family involvement, and openness to visits and participation. - Negative indicators: none clearly evident; the system’s public materials emphasize partnership and formation rather than consumer-centric engagement.

Why this rating - Yellowstone is clearly aligned with the classical ideal of parents as co-teachers and active participants in the educational formation process. The public materials strongly emphasize partnership with families, parental formation, and openness to parent participation, supporting a CLASSICAL rating for Element 6.

Aggregate assessment - Element 1: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 2: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 3: NOT CLASSICAL - Element 4: NOT CLASSICAL - Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- Document and publish a clear, public-facing Classical Curriculum: articulate a Trivium (grammar-logic-rhetoric) sequence, explicit Great Books and Great Conversation integration, and a through-line history curriculum, with sample units and texts. This would push Element 3 toward CLASSICAL.
- Implement and publicize explicit Socratic pedagogy and scholé practices: provide teacher training and publish examples of Socratic seminars, memory work, and contemplative days; include student exemplars and seminar transcripts to demonstrate method. This would push Element 4 toward CLASSICAL.
- Strengthen and publish a “Living Curriculum” framing of the Faculty: publicly articulate the faculty as mentors and living exemplars, with a documented portrait of teachers and a structured professional development plan aligned with classical pedagogy. This would push Element 5 toward CLASSICAL.
- Integrate liturgical and communal practices where appropriate: if the school intends to weave liturgical or communal aesthetics into classroom practice, publish a clear plan for liturgical rhythms or prayer/formation activities that align with the faith dimension in Element 1, moving toward CLASSICAL.
- Expand Great Books exposure and Great Conversation through graded reading lists and discussion-based assessments across divisions: this would strengthen Element 1’s and Element 3’s alignment with classical education and shift the aggregate rating toward CLASSICAL.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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